The Fear Ladder

Five spooky stories that get scarier — and the words to tell them

B1–B2 · LISTENING + SPEAKING

Name:



English Coffee Break

PREMIUM ESL MATERIALS

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1.1 Scariest thing and the first rungs

B1 HELPER
START WITH
It happened when … · I was … · Then … · In the end …

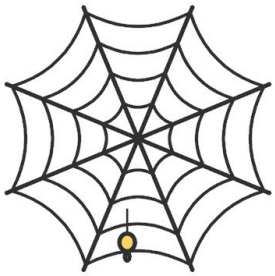
Exercise 1

My first answer. Tell your teacher.

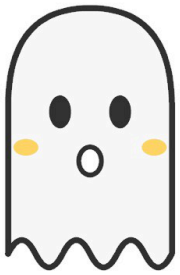
A



B



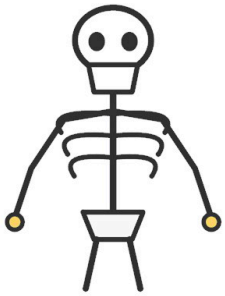
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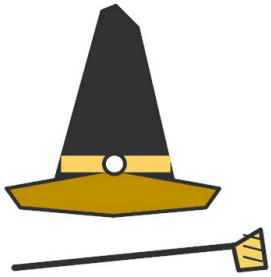
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E



F



Exercise 2

Match the picture and the word.

Write the letter of the picture next to each word.

ghost	witch	pumpkin
bat	skeleton	cobweb

Exercise 3

Choose the correct word.

1. The film was very _____ . (frightened / frightening)
2. I was _____ of the dark. (scared / scary)
3. My little brother is _____ of dogs. (terrified / terrifying)



4. That old house looks _____ . (scary / scared)
5. She is afraid _____ spiders. (of / from)
6. He felt great _____ when the lights went out. (fear / afraid)

Exercise 4

Write the sentence again with the key word. Keep the meaning. Do not change the key word.

0. I was very scared when I heard the noise. **FEAR**
1. She is scared of flying. **FEAR**
2. The film was frightening. **SCARED**
3. The children were very scared of the big dog. **TERRIFIED**

1.2 Lucky or unlucky?



LISTEN · PART 1

Exercise 5

Listen.

1. Which superstition is different in Britain?
2. Write three words you did not catch: 1 _____ 2 _____ 3

WORD	CZECH	EXAMPLE
superstition	pověra	"A broken mirror is a superstition."
bad luck	smůla	"Walking under a ladder brings bad luck."
good luck	štěstí	"In Britain, a black cat brings good luck."
believe in	věřit v / na	"I don't believe in ghosts."
afraid of	bát se (čeho)	"She is afraid of black cats."

EXTRA RUNGS

WORD	CZECH	EXAMPLE
avoid + -ing	vyhýbat se	"He avoids walking under ladders."
curse	kletba	"They say the old house has a curse."

Exercise 6

Circle the best meaning.



1. A **superstition** is …
   A) a type of scary film (horor)
   B) a belief that things bring good or bad luck (pověra)
   C) a strong fear of animals (fobie)
2. "I'm **afraid of** spiders." means …
   A) Mám rád pavouky. B) Pavouci mě otravují. C) Mám strach z pavouků.
3. **Bad luck** is …
   A) smůla B) štěstí C) zlost
4. "She **avoids** walking under ladders." means …
   A) Často chodí pod žebříky.
   B) Nechodí pod žebříky, vyhýbá se jim.
   C) Neumí chodit pod žebříky.
5. "Do you **believe in** ghosts?" means …
   A) Věříš na duchy? B) Vidíš duchy? C) Bojíš se duchů?



6. A **curse** is …

A) požehnání B) vtip C) kletba

Word bank

afraid	bad luck	bad luck	believe in	curse	good luck

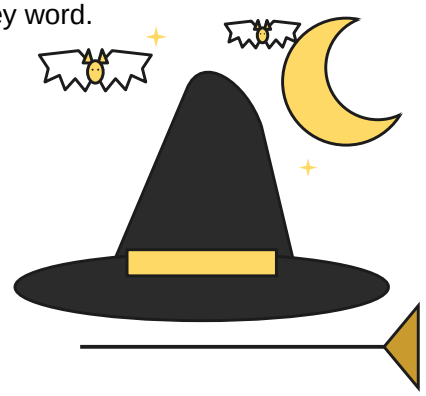
Exercise 7

Listen again. Fill the gaps.

1. In the United States, many people believe that a black cat brings _____ if it walks across your path.
2. Some people are so _____ of it that they turn around and walk the other way.
3. For them, a black cat brings _____.
4. If you break a mirror, you will have seven years of _____.
5. It is almost like a small _____.
6. So, do you _____ superstitions?

Exercise 8

Write the sentence again with the key word. Keep the meaning. Do not change the key word.



0. Some people think black cats are unlucky. **LUCK**
1. In the USA, it is unlucky to walk under a ladder. **BRINGS**
2. She is scared to break a mirror. **AFRAID**
3. My grandmother thinks superstitions are real. **BELIEVER**
4. I never walk under ladders. **AVOID**
5. In Britain, black cats mean good luck. **CONSIDERED**
6. People say a broken mirror brings bad luck. **SUPPOSED**

Exercise 9

Read each sentence. Write F (a fact we can check), S (a story or a belief) or N (nobody knows for sure). Then say the sentence: “It is a fact that …”, “Some people say …” or “Nobody knows for sure …”.

1. In Britain, many people think a black cat brings good luck.
2. If you break a mirror, you will have seven years of bad luck.
3. People avoid ladders because a ladder makes a holy triangle.
4. In Britain and Ireland, people say "touch wood".

1.3 Where does Halloween come from?

LISTEN · PART 2

Exercise 10

Listen.

1. How many ideas about the origin of Halloween do you hear?
2. Write three words you did not catch: 1 _____ 2 _____ 3

WORD	CZECH	EXAMPLE
costume	kostým	"She wore a witch costume."
trick-or-treat	koledovat na Halloween	"The children go trick-or-treating."
jack-o'-lantern	dýňová lucerna	"We put a candle in the jack-o'-lantern."
haunted house	strašidelný dům	"We visited a haunted house."
spooky	strašidelný, tajuplný	"The old castle looked spooky."

EXTRA RUNGS

WORD	CZECH	EXAMPLE
harvest	sklizeň	"The harvest is in autumn."

Exercise 11

Circle the best meaning.

1. A **costume** is …
   A) special clothes for a party or a play (kostým)
   B) a type of sweet (bonbon)
   C) a pumpkin with a face (dýně)
2. "The children go **trick-or-treating**." means …
   A) Děti jedou na výlet.
   B) Děti chodí po domech a vybírají sladkosti.
   C) Děti dělají kouzla.
3. A **jack-o'-lantern** is …
   A) strašidelný dům B) kostým C) vydlabaná dýně se svíčkou
4. A **haunted house** is a house where …
   A) lidé říkají, že tam straší B) žije hodně dětí C) se prodávají dýně
5. "The castle looks **spooky**." means …
   A) Hrad je nový. B) Hrad vypadá strašidelně. C) Hrad je velký.
6. **Harvest** is …
   A) sklizeň B) zima C) hostina



Word bank

costume	haunted house	harvest	jack-o'-lantern	spooky	trick-or-treat

Exercise 12

Listen again. Fill the gaps.

1. It was celebrated in Ireland and Scotland at the end of the _____.
2. Some people think this was the first _____.
3. In Scotland and Ireland, people also wore a _____ and visited their neighbours.
4. This is the _____.
5. Many adults visit a _____ for fun.
6. A _____ night is exciting, and a little fear can be fun.

Exercise 13

Write the sentence again with the key word. Keep the meaning. Do not change the key word.

0. The children wore costumes for Halloween. **DRESSED**
1. Children trick-or-treat on 31 October. **WHEN**
2. The Irish carved jack-o'-lanterns from turnips. **MADE**
3. Haunted houses are so popular that people pay for them. **SUCH**
4. At night, the old castle felt strange and scary. **SPOOKY**
5. People celebrated when they finished collecting the crops. **END**

Exercise 14

Read each sentence. Write F (a fact we can check), S (a story or a belief) or N (nobody knows for sure). Then say the sentence: “It is a fact that …”, “Some people say …” or “Nobody knows for sure …”.

1. Halloween is on the thirty-first of October.

2. Halloween comes from the old festival Samhain.
3. The name "jack-o'-lantern" comes from a man called Stingy Jack.
4. The words "trick or treat" first appeared in print in 1917.

LESSON 2 · THE HORROR CLASS

2.1 Three horror films

LISTEN · PART 3

Exercise 15

Listen. Write down the real thing behind each film.

1. Film 1 Halloween: the real thing behind it:
2. Film 2 A Nightmare on Elm Street: the real thing behind it:
3. Film 3 Friday the Thirteenth: what the producer wanted:
4. Write three words you did not catch: 1 _____ 2 _____ 3

WORD	CZECH	EXAMPLE
mask	maska	"He wore a white mask."
creepy	mrazivý, nepříjemný	"That old doll is creepy."
goosebumps	husí kůže	"The story gave me goosebumps."
nightmare	noční můra	"I had a nightmare last night."
terrified	vyděšený k smrti	"She was terrified of the dark."

EXTRA RUNGS

WORD	CZECH	EXAMPLE
inspired by	inspirován (čím)	"The film was inspired by a news story."
based on	založený na	"The film is based on a true story."

Exercise 16

Circle the best meaning.

1. A **mask** is …
   A) maska B) klobouk C) rukavice
2. "That old doll is **creepy**." means …
   A) Ta panenka je velmi stará.
   B) Ta panenka je drahá.
   C) Z té panenky mi běhá mráz po zádech.
3. If a story gives you **goosebumps**, you …
   A) máš husí kůži z napětí nebo strachu B) máš hlad C) je ti horko
4. A **nightmare** is …
   A) zpráva z novin B) špatný sen, který tě vyděsí C) druh masky
5. "She was **terrified**." means …
   A) Byla trochu nervózní. B) Byla unavená. C) Byla strašně vyděšená.
6. "The film was **inspired by** a news story." means …
   A) Film dal zprávě nápad.
   B) Zpráva dala tvůrcům nápad na film.
   C) Film se natáčel v novinách.



Word bank

based on	creepy	goosebumps	inspired by	mask	nightmare	terrified

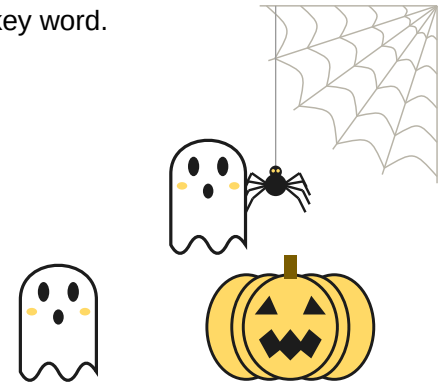
Exercise 17

Listen again. Fill the gaps.

1. He wears a white _____.
2. Carpenter found the stare _____, and he used it for his character.
3. The teenagers are _____ of falling asleep, because that is where the killer finds them.
4. The director, Wes Craven, was _____ real life.
5. A stranger staring through a window is a creepy idea, and it gives many people _____.
6. The boy died in the middle of a _____.
7. As far as we know, the film is not _____ a real event.

Exercise 18

Write the sentence again with the key word. Keep the meaning. Do not change the key word.



0. After the film, I had bad dreams every night. **NIGHTMARES**
1. He wears a white mask so nobody can see his face. **HIDE**
2. The film was so scary that I couldn't watch it alone. **TOO**
3. When she stared at me, my skin went cold. **GOOSEBUMPS**
4. I think that old doll is strange and frightening. **FIND**
5. Craven took the idea from a real news story. **INSPIRED**
6. The film is not a true story. It is made up. **BASED**

Exercise 19

Read each sentence. Write F (a fact we can check), S (a story or a belief) or N (nobody knows for sure). Then say the sentence: “It is a fact that …”, “Some people say …” or “Nobody knows for sure …”.

1. Michael Myers' mask was a Captain Kirk mask painted white.
2. Friday the thirteenth became unlucky because of a famous old legend.
3. In one study from 2011, about eight in ten of the sleep deaths had a heart problem.
4. Friday the thirteenth brings bad luck.

2.2 The mountain mystery

LISTEN · PART 4

Exercise 20

Listen. Write down the strange clues the searchers found. Write at least three.

1. The strange clues: 1 _____ 2 _____ 3 _____ (more …)
2. Write three words you did not catch: 1 _____ 2 _____ 3

WORD	CZECH	EXAMPLE
search	pátrání; pátrat	"A search party went up the mountain."
mystery	záhada	"It is still a mystery."
explain	vysvětlit	"Nobody can explain it."

EXTRA RUNGS

WORD	CZECH	EXAMPLE
eerie	tísnivý, strašidelně tichý	"an eerie silence"
dread	tíživá hrůza, obava	"She waited with dread."
petrified	ztuhlý hrůzou	"He was petrified with fear."
spine-chilling	mrazivý, děsivý	"a spine-chilling story"

TOP RUNG (OPTIONAL)

WORD	CZECH	EXAMPLE
unnerving	znepokojivý	"The most unnerving detail is the tent."
harrowing	otřesný	"a harrowing story"

Exercise 21

Circle the best meaning.

1. A **search** party …
   A) hledá někoho, kdo se ztratil B) slaví narozeniny C) vyrábí stany
2. A **mystery** is …
   A) historie B) záhada C) mapa
3. "Nobody can **explain** it." means …
   A) Nikdo to nechce vidět. B) Nikdo to neumí vysvětlit. C) Nikdo to nechce slyšet.
4. "an **eerie** silence" is …
   A) tísnivé, strašidelné ticho B) hlasité ticho C) příjemné ticho
5. "She waited with **dread**." means …
   A) Čekala s tíživou hrůzou. B) Čekala s radostí. C) Čekala dlouho.
6. If you are **petrified**, you are …
   A) trochu ospalý B) ztuhlý hrůzou C) velmi hladový





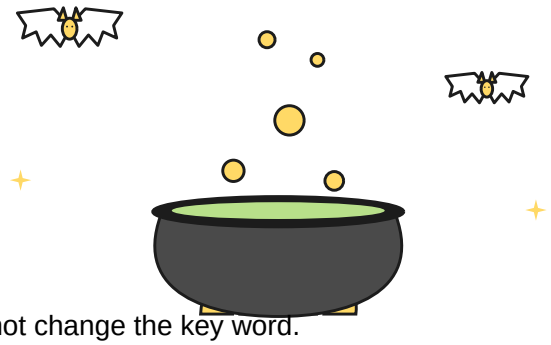
Word bank

dread	eerie	explain	mystery	petrified	search	unnerving (extra)

Exercise 22

Listen again. Fill the gaps.

1. At home, the families waited with growing _____.
2. Finally, a _____ party went up the mountain.
3. There was an _____ silence on the mountain.
4. Many scientists have tried to _____ it.
5. Something made them run. They were probably _____.
6. It is a spine-chilling _____.
7. **Extra.** The most _____ detail is still the tent.



Exercise 23

Write the sentence again with the key word. Keep the meaning. Do not change the key word.

0. The mountain was strangely quiet and a bit frightening. **EERIE**
1. The hikers were so scared that they could not move. **TOO**
2. People went up the mountain to look for the hikers. **SEARCH**
3. Nobody knows why the hikers left the tent. **MYSTERY**

4. The families were very afraid of the bad news. **DREAD**
5. Some scientists think an avalanche is the reason. **EXPLAINS**
6. **Extra.** The story gave us a cold feeling down our backs. **SUCH**

Exercise 24

Read each sentence. Write F (a fact we can check), S (a story or a belief) or N (nobody knows for sure). Then say the sentence: “It is a fact that …”, “Some people say …” or “Nobody knows for sure …”.

1. The tent was cut open from the inside.
2. Russian officials said in 2020 that it was an avalanche.
3. A small avalanche explains everything that happened to the hikers.
4. Yuri was the only person from the trip who came home.

2.3 The devil made me do it





LISTEN · PART 5





Exercise 25

Listen.

1. The lawyer wanted to say:
2. The judge decided:
3. Write three words you did not catch: 1 _____ 2 _____ 3

WORD	CZECH	EXAMPLE
trial	soudní proces	"The trial lasted two weeks."
judge	soudce	"The judge said no."
guilty	vinný	"The jury found him guilty."
possessed	posedlý	"They said the boy was possessed."

EXTRA RUNGS

WORD	CZECH	EXAMPLE
evidence	důkaz(y)	"There was no evidence."
claim	tvrdit; tvrzení	"She claimed it was true."
sentenced	odsouzen (k trestu)	"He was sentenced to ten years."
manslaughter	zabití (ne vražda)	"He was guilty of manslaughter, not murder."

TOP RUNG (OPTIONAL)

WORD	CZECH	EXAMPLE
sinister	zlověstný	"It is a sinister story."

Exercise 26

Circle the best meaning.

1. A **trial** is …
   A) soudní proces B) výlet C) zkouška v obchodě
2. The **judge** is the person who …
   A) hájí obžalovaného B) rozhoduje u soudu C) píše noviny
3. If a jury finds someone **guilty**, it decides that he …
   A) je nevinný B) lže C) to udělal
4. "The boy was **possessed**." means …

A) Chlapec byl posedlý (podle rodiny ovládaný démonem).
B) Chlapec byl nemocný.
C) Chlapec byl bohatý.



5. "There was no **evidence**." means …
   A) Nebyl žádný soudce. B) Nebyl žádný svědek. C) Nebyly žádné důkazy.
6. "She **claimed** that it was true." means …
   A) Tvrdila, že je to pravda. B) Doufala, že je to pravda. C) Ukázala, že je to pravda.

Word bank

claimed	evidence	guilty	judge	possessed	trial	sinister (extra)

Exercise 27

Listen again. Fill the gaps.

1. Before this, a local family had said that their young son was _____ by a demon.
2. The day after the killing, Lorraine Warren _____ that Johnson was possessed too.
3. At the _____, Johnson's lawyer first wanted to say that Johnson was not guilty because he was possessed.
4. But the _____ refused.
5. The judge said there was no _____ that possession could be a defence.
6. In the end, the jury found Johnson _____ of manslaughter, not murder.
7. **Extra.** It is a _____ story, but the only thing we know for sure is that a real man died.



Exercise 28

Write the sentence again with the key word. Keep the meaning. Do not change the key word.

0. Johnson went to court for killing his landlord. **TRIAL**
1. The family said a demon controlled the boy. **POSSESSED**
2. There was no proof, so the judge refused it. **LACK**
3. The jury decided that Johnson did it. **GUILTY**
4. Lorraine Warren said he was possessed. **CLAIM**
5. A judge gave him ten to twenty years in prison. **SENTENCED**
6. **Extra.** It was a frightening and evil story. **SINISTER**

Exercise 29

Read each sentence. Write F (a fact we can check), S (a story or a belief) or N (nobody knows for sure). Then say the sentence: “It is a fact that …”, “Some people say …” or “Nobody knows for sure …”.



1. The judge refused the possession defence.
2. The jury found Johnson guilty of manslaughter.
3. Johnson killed Alan Bono because a demon possessed him.
4. The case became famous as "the devil made me do it".

2.4 Closing the ladder



SAY WHY
SENTENCE FRAME
I think … is stronger than … because …

Exercise 30

Put the words in order, from a little scared to very scared. There is no perfect answer. Tell your teacher why.

Your ladders (strongest at the top, weakest at the bottom)

RUNG	HOW I FEEL	WHAT CAUSES IT	EXTRA RUNGS
5	_____	_____	_____
4	_____	_____	_____
3	_____	_____	_____
2	_____	_____	_____
1	_____	_____	_____

LANGUAGE BOX

SAY IT

In my opinion … · I think … because … · Some people say … but I … · For example …

Exercise 31 A

Pick the questions you like. Talk to your teacher.

1. Do you have a lucky number, a lucky day or a lucky thing?
2. Which of the four superstitions from Part 1 do you follow, even a little?
3. What is your favourite thing about Halloween — the costumes, the sweets, the films, or something else?
4. Have you ever been in a haunted house or a spooky place? What was it like?

Exercise 32 B



Pick the questions you like. Talk to your teacher.



5. Should Czech children celebrate Halloween, or keep older traditions such as Dušičky? Why?
6. Why do people enjoy being scared by films and haunted houses?
7. Which of the five stories was the scariest for you? Choose a rung on the Fear Ladder.
8. Is it a good idea to believe in luck? Why, or why not?

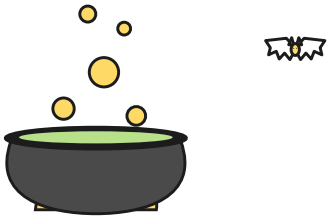
Exercise 33 C

Pick the questions you like. Talk to your teacher.

9. A film is "inspired by a true story". Does "true" make it scarier, or is it disrespectful to the real people?
10. Imagine you are an investigator in the mountain mystery. What do you check first, and why?
11. Should the media tell dramatic stories about real deaths for entertainment?
12. Are superstitions harmless? When can they become a problem?

Exercise 34





My second answer. Tell your teacher. Tick the words you used.

1. Other words I used:

Words I used

[ ] scared	[ ] afraid	[ ] frightened	[ ] terrified
[ ] creepy	[ ] goosebumps	[ ] nightmare	[ ] spooky
[ ] eerie	[ ] petrified	[ ] dread	

Exercise 35

Tick: not yet, nearly or yes.

Can-do check

I CAN…	NOT YET	NEARLY	YES
1. say what scared me, using words from the Fear Ladder.			
2. explain the difference between scared and scary.			
3. say what a superstition is and give two examples.			
4. explain two ideas about where Halloween comes from.			
5. retell one story from the lesson in my own words.			
6. say a sentence again with a key word.			
7. name one real thing behind a horror film.			
8. tell the mountain mystery in five sentences.			

Payoff

Finish the sentence. Use one Fear Ladder word.

1. The scariest thing in this pack was _____ because it was _____.



Key

Check your own work. Where you got something wrong, go back to that section — not through the whole worksheet.

1.1 · Exercise 1

No key for this part — there is no single right answer.

1.1 · Exercise 2

A bat · B cobweb · C ghost · D pumpkin · E skeleton · F witch

1.1 · Exercise 3

1 frightening
2 scared
3 terrified
4 scary
5 of
6 fear

1.1 · Exercise 4

0 **When I heard the noise, I was full of fear.** · also: I felt a lot of fear when I heard the noise.
1 **She has a fear of flying.** · also: She has a real fear of flying.
2 **I was scared by the film.** · also: The film made me scared. / I felt scared watching the film.
3 **The big dog terrified the children.** · also: The children were terrified of the big dog.

1.2 · Exercise 5

MODEL ANSWER The black cat (bad luck in the USA, good luck in Britain). Words will vary; they are the student's own gap list. Use them in 1.2.

1.2 · Exercise 6

1 B · 2 C · 3 A · 4 B · 5 A · 6 C

1.2 · Exercise 7

1 bad luck
2 afraid
3 good luck
4 bad luck
5 curse
6 believe in

1.2 · Exercise 8

0 **Some people think black cats bring bad luck.** · also: Some people think black cats are bad luck.
1 **In the USA, walking under a ladder brings bad luck.**
2 **She is afraid of breaking a mirror.** · also: She is afraid to break a mirror.
3 **My grandmother is a believer in superstitions.** · also: My grandmother is a big believer in superstitions.
4 **I avoid walking under ladders.** · also: I always avoid walking under ladders.
5 **In Britain, black cats are considered lucky.** · also: In Britain, black cats are considered to be lucky.
6 **A broken mirror is supposed to bring bad luck.** · also: Breaking a mirror is supposed to bring bad luck.

1.2 · Exercise 9

1 F
2 S
3 N
4 F

MODEL ANSWER 1 It is a fact that many British people think a black cat brings good luck.
MODEL ANSWER 2 Some people say a broken mirror brings seven years of bad luck.
MODEL ANSWER 3 Nobody knows for sure why people avoid ladders.
MODEL ANSWER 4 It is a fact that British and Irish people say "touch wood".

1.3 · Exercise 10

MODEL ANSWER Two (Samhain / a Christian holiday).

1.3 · Exercise 11

1 A · 2 B · 3 C · 4 A · 5 B · 6 A

1.3 · Exercise 12

1 harvest
2 trick-or-treat
3 costume
4 jack-o'-lantern
5 haunted house
6 spooky

1.3 · Exercise 13

0 **The children dressed up in costumes for Halloween.**
1 **31 October is the night when children go trick-or-treating.**
2 **In Ireland, jack-o'-lanterns were made from turnips.**
3 **Haunted houses are such popular places that people pay for them.**
4 **At night, there was something spooky about the old castle.**
5 **People celebrated at the end of the harvest.** · also: People celebrated the end of the harvest.

1.3 · Exercise 14

1 F
2 N
3 S
4 F

MODEL ANSWER 1 It is a fact that Halloween is on 31 October.

MODEL ANSWER 2 Nobody knows for sure where Halloween comes from.

MODEL ANSWER 3 Some people say the name comes from Stingy Jack, but it is only a story.

MODEL ANSWER 4 It is a fact that the words first appeared in print in 1917.

2.1 · Exercise 15

MODEL ANSWER Film 1: a young patient's cold stare, seen in a hospital in Kentucky. Film 2: an old man staring through a window / a bully named Fred Krueger / news about refugees dying in their sleep (any of these). Film 3: to copy the success of *Halloween* (no real event behind it).

2.1 · Exercise 16

1 A · 2 C · 3 A · 4 B · 5 C · 6 B

2.1 · Exercise 17

1 mask
2 creepy
3 terrified
4 inspired by
5 goosebumps
6 nightmare
7 based on

2.1 · Exercise 18

0 **The film gave me nightmares every night.** · also: After the film, I had nightmares every night.
1 **He wears a white mask to hide his face.** · also: He wears a white mask so he can hide his face.
2 **The film was too scary for me to watch alone.** · also: The film was too frightening for me to watch alone.
3 **Her stare gave me goosebumps.** · also: When she stared at me, I got goosebumps.
4 **I find that old doll strange and frightening.** · also: I find that old doll creepy.
5 **Craven was inspired by a real news story.** · also: The film was inspired by a real news story.
6 **The film is not based on a true story.** · also: The film isn't based on a true story. It is made up.

2.1 · Exercise 19

1 F
2 N
3 F
4 S

MODEL ANSWER 1 It is a fact that the mask was a Captain Kirk mask.

MODEL ANSWER 2 Nobody knows for sure where the idea comes from.

MODEL ANSWER 3 It is a fact that a 2011 study found a heart problem in about eight in ten cases.

MODEL ANSWER 4 Some people say Friday the thirteenth brings bad luck.

2.2 · Exercise 20

MODEL ANSWER (any three) The tent was cut open from the inside · footprints of people in socks only · two bodies almost without clothes · broken branches high in the tree · serious injuries but no wounds on the outside · clothes taken from dead friends.

2.2 · Exercise 21

1 A · 2 B · 3 B · 4 A · 5 A · 6 B

2.2 · Exercise 22

1 dread
2 search
3 eerie
4 explain
5 petrified
6 mystery
7 unnerving

2.2 · Exercise 23

0 **There was an eerie silence on the mountain.** · also: The mountain was eerie and quiet.
1 **The hikers were too scared to move.** · also: The hikers were too petrified to move.
2 **A search party went up the mountain to look for the hikers.**
3 **It is still a mystery why the hikers left the tent.** · also: Why the hikers left the tent is a mystery.
4 **The families waited for the bad news with dread.**
5 **Some scientists think an avalanche explains what happened.**
6 **It was such a spine-chilling story.** · also: It was such a spine-chilling story that we felt cold.

2.2 · Exercise 24

1 F
2 F
3 N
4 F

MODEL ANSWER 1 It is a fact that the tent was cut open from the inside.

MODEL ANSWER 2 It is a fact that officials said it was an avalanche.

MODEL ANSWER 3 Nobody knows for sure what happened; the study explains only some of the injuries.

MODEL ANSWER 4 It is a fact that Yuri was the only one who came home.

2.3 · Exercise 25

MODEL ANSWER The lawyer wanted to say that Johnson was not guilty because he was possessed. The judge refused (no evidence), so the jury never heard it.

2.3 · Exercise 26

1 A · 2 B · 3 C · 4 A · 5 C · 6 A

2.3 · Exercise 27

1 possessed
2 claimed
3 trial
4 judge

5 evidence
6 guilty
7 sinister

2.3 · Exercise 28

0 **Johnson went on trial for killing his landlord.** · also: Johnson was put on trial for killing his landlord.
1 **The family said the boy was possessed by a demon.** · also: The family said a demon possessed the boy.
2 **Because of a lack of evidence, the judge refused it.** · also: The judge refused it because of the lack of proof.
3 **Johnson was found guilty by the jury.** · also: The jury found Johnson guilty.
4 **Lorraine Warren made the claim that he was possessed.**
5 **He was sentenced to ten to twenty years in prison.**
6 **There was something sinister about the story.** · also: The story was frightening and sinister.

2.3 · Exercise 29

1 F
2 F
3 S
4 F

MODEL ANSWER 1 It is a fact that the judge refused the defence.
MODEL ANSWER 2 It is a fact that the jury found him guilty of manslaughter.
MODEL ANSWER 3 Some people say he was possessed, but the court never accepted it.
MODEL ANSWER 4 It is a fact that the case became famous with that name.

2.4 · Exercise 30

How I feel: afraid · scared · frightened · terrified · petrified
What causes it: spooky · creepy · scary · eerie · spine-chilling
Extra rungs: unnerving · sinister · macabre · harrowing · visceral
Accept: Neighbours swapped; afraid and scared are close; bone-chilling may replace spine-chilling.

2.4 · Exercise 31–33

No key for this part — there is no single right answer.

2.4 · Exercise 34

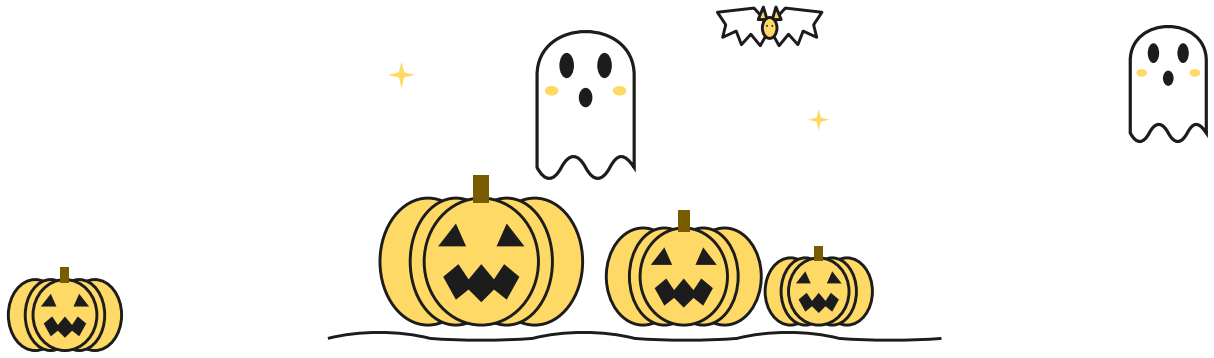
No key for this part — there is no single right answer.

2.4 · Exercise 35

No key for this part — there is no single right answer.

Payoff

MODEL ANSWER The scariest thing in this pack was the mountain mystery because it was eerie.



Transcripts

Read only after listening.





1.2 Lucky or unlucky?

Welcome. Today we begin with four superstitions that are well known in the United States.

A superstition is a belief that something brings good luck or bad luck. Some people believe in superstitions. Other people say, "That's silly." But many of them still avoid the ladder!

Number one: the black cat. In the United States, many people believe that a black cat brings bad luck if it walks across your path. Some people are so afraid of it that they turn around and walk the other way. But in Britain, many people think the opposite. For them, a black cat brings good luck.

Number two: the ladder. Many people believe it is bad luck to walk under a ladder. They are afraid of it, so they always walk around. Some people say a ladder against a wall makes a triangle, and the triangle was a holy shape in ancient Egypt. Nobody knows if this is true.

Number three: the mirror. If you break a mirror, you will have seven years of bad luck. It is almost like a small curse.

Number four: knock on wood. After you say something good, like "I never get ill," you knock on wood. Then your good luck will not disappear. In Britain and Ireland, people say "touch wood" instead. None of these four superstitions is only American.

So, do you believe in superstitions?

1.3 Where does Halloween come from?

Halloween is on the thirty-first of October, and it has a spooky history. Where does it come from? Nobody knows for sure, but historians have two main ideas.

The first idea is that Halloween comes from an old festival called Samhain. It was celebrated in Ireland and Scotland at the end of the harvest. Some historians think that people believed spirits came closer to the living at this time.

The second idea is that Halloween began as a Christian holiday. The first of November was a special day for the saints. The evening before was called All Hallows' Eve, and later this became the word "Halloween". The second of November is a day to remember all the dead. So Halloween is the start of a three-day season.

Many Halloween customs are very old. Hundreds of years ago, poor people in Britain went from door to door and asked for small cakes. In return, they prayed for the dead. Some people think this was the first trick-or-treat. In Scotland and Ireland, people also wore a costume and visited their neighbours.

In the nineteenth century, many Irish and Scottish people moved to America and took their customs with them. In Ireland, people carved a face in a turnip and put a candle inside. In America, they used a pumpkin instead, because a pumpkin is bigger and softer. This is the jack-o'-lantern. People still put a jack-o'-lantern in the window today. There is an Irish story about Stingy Jack, a man who tricked the devil. Some people say this is where the name "jack-o'-lantern" comes from. But it is only a story.

The words "trick or treat" first appeared in print in 1917, in a Canadian newspaper. By the 1930s, trick-or-treating was popular in the United States. Today, children put on a costume and go from house to house. Many adults visit a haunted house for fun. It is a house full of pretend ghosts and monsters. Some people say that real haunted houses exist, but there is no proof. A spooky night is exciting, and a little fear can be fun.

2.1 Three horror films

Now three famous horror films. Each one has a real story behind it.

Film number one: Halloween, from 1978. In the film, a boy kills his sister on Halloween night. Fifteen years later, he comes back to his town. He wears a white mask. His name is Michael Myers.

Here is a surprise about the mask. It was a mask of Captain Kirk, from the television series Star Trek. The film crew bought it in a shop and painted it white.

And here is the real story. The director, John Carpenter, visited a hospital in Kentucky when he was a student. There he met a young patient with a cold, empty stare. Carpenter found the stare creepy, and he used it for his character. The film is not based on a true story, but the stare was real.

Film number two: A Nightmare on Elm Street, from 1984. In this film, a killer attacks teenagers in their dreams. If they die in the dream, they die in real life. The idea of a killer in your dreams gives many people goosebumps. The teenagers are terrified of falling asleep, because that is where the killer finds them. His name is Freddy Krueger. He has a burned face, a red and green sweater, and a glove with knives.

The director, Wes Craven, was inspired by real life. As a boy, he saw an old man outside his window. The man stared at him, and then walked away. A stranger staring through a window is a creepy idea, and it gives many people goosebumps. Craven also named the killer after a boy who bullied him at school.

There is a sadder story too. In the late 1970s and early 1980s, a newspaper in Los Angeles wrote about refugees from Southeast Asia who died in their sleep. Craven said that one story was about a boy who was afraid to sleep. The boy died in the middle of a nightmare. At the time, doctors could not explain these deaths. Today, many doctors think that hidden heart problems explain a lot of them, but not every case. Doctors later gave these deaths a name. In one study from 2011, about eight in ten cases had a heart problem.

Film number three: Friday the Thirteenth, from 1980. Young people work at a summer camp called Camp Crystal Lake, and someone is killing them, one by one. As far as we know, the film is not based on a real event. The producer was inspired by the success of Halloween, and he wanted to make something similar. It worked. The film cost less than a million dollars, and it made almost sixty million.

The title comes from a superstition. In many Western countries, Friday the thirteenth is an unlucky day. Nobody knows for sure where this idea comes from. In 1881, in New York, a group called the Thirteen Club met on Friday the thirteenth. They wanted to show that the superstition was false. In Spanish-speaking countries and in Greece, the unlucky day is Tuesday the thirteenth. In Italy, it is Friday the seventeenth. Some people are terrified of Friday the thirteenth, and there is a very long name for this fear.

2.2 The mountain mystery





This is a true story, and it is a famous mystery.

In January 1959, ten hikers, mostly university students from what was then the Soviet Union, went on a winter trip in the Ural Mountains. Their leader was a twenty-three-year-old student called Igor Dyatlov. They were experienced hikers, and the weather was freezing. Early in the trip, one student, Yuri, felt ill, so he went home. Nine people continued. On the first of February, a snowstorm came. The group stopped on an open mountain slope and put up their tent for the night.

Weeks later, the group had not come back. At home, the families waited with growing dread. They asked for a search. Finally, a search party went up the mountain. On the twenty-sixth of February, they found the tent. It was empty and half covered in snow. All the shoes and clothes were still inside. Then the searchers saw something strange. The tent had been cut open, from the inside.

Footprints led away from the tent, towards a forest. Some of the people were wearing only socks. The footprints went on for about five hundred metres. Then the snow covered them. There was an eerie silence on the mountain.

At the edge of the forest, under a tall tree, the searchers found a small fire that had gone out. Two of the hikers were lying there, almost without clothes. They had died from the cold. Branches high in the tree were broken. Between the tree and the tent, the searchers found three more bodies. It looked as if they were trying to walk back. The night had been extremely cold, about thirty degrees below zero. Five hikers were dead, and four were still missing.

The last four hikers were not found until May. They were under four metres of snow, in a ravine near the tree. Three of them had very serious injuries to the chest and head. But there were no wounds on the outside of their bodies. Some were wearing clothes that belonged to their dead friends.

The investigators wrote that the group died because of a "compelling natural force". Then the case was closed, and the files were kept secret.

Yuri was the only person from the trip who came home. For sixty years, people asked: what was this force? Many scientists have tried to explain it. In 2020, Russian officials said it was an avalanche. In 2021, two scientists in Switzerland said that a small avalanche could explain some of the injuries. One of them said: "We don't want to pretend that we have solved it." But many people disagree. The most unnerving detail is still the tent. Why did experienced hikers cut their own tent open? Why did they run out into the freezing night, some of them without shoes? Something made them run. They were probably petrified. Nobody can explain it for sure. It is a spine-chilling mystery.

2.3 The devil made me do it

This last story is a true court case from the United States. A real man died, so we tell it carefully.

In February 1981, in Brookfield, Connecticut, a young man called Arne Johnson killed his landlord, Alan Bono, with a knife. Bono died a few hours later. Johnson was charged with murder.

Before this, a local family had said that their young son was possessed by a demon. They asked two famous investigators of the supernatural, Ed and Lorraine Warren, for help. The day after the killing, Lorraine Warren claimed that Johnson was possessed too.

At the trial, Johnson's lawyer first wanted to say that Johnson was not guilty because he was possessed. But the judge refused. The judge said there was no evidence that possession could be a defence. So the jury never heard that idea.

In the end, the jury found Johnson guilty of manslaughter, not murder. The verdict came in November 1981, and the sentence in December. He was sentenced to ten to twenty years in prison, and he served about five.

After the trial, the case became famous as "the devil made me do it", and it later appeared in books and films. But many people doubt this claim of possession. One member of the family later said that the Warrens' story was a hoax. The court never accepted it. It is a sinister story, but the only thing we know for sure is that a real man died.





